

interested in civil services or setting up businesses. The survey results could now add more support groups to Nitish's EBC base, especially those who, for the first time, feel they can assert their numerical strength.

The caste survey results have rocked the political scene when many thought Nitish's days as a social engineering spearhead were over after his party punched below its weight in the 2020 assembly polls. But within three years, he is back centre stage as the biggest social justice champion of them all.

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Top JD(U) sources say Nitish believes the 50 per cent cap on reservation is the biggest impediment to states extending equitable opportunities to the OBCs. Nitish has spoken about this while making a case for a nationwide caste census, but the arguments are not without a political spin. Having dumped the BJP in August 2022, he is now credited with bringing together the national opposition INDIA alliance. The alliance will look to use the survey findings to puncture the BJP, which derives its electoral strength from portraying a picture of Hindu homogeneity versus the other.

The aftershocks of the Bihar caste survey are already visible, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi attacking the Opposition (of course without mentioning the survey) for dividing the country along caste lines. There is a strong perception in the opposition camp that the quota plank can queer the BJP's Hindutva pitch, which has helped it make inroads into sections of the EBCs.

In fact, this could well be the most valid reason why the BJP appears unwilling to conduct an all-India caste census, for it could open a Pandora's box for them. All this then positions Nitish as the man of the moment. Could it be that he has found the chink in the BJP's armour? If the issue snowballs in the coming months, and if the electoral dice fall in INDIA's favour, we could well see the Bihar CM in a different, national avatar. Indeed, he could become as indispensable to the country as he currently is to Bihar. ■

mins and Baniyas, two elite caste groups, the BJP has over the years, expanded its political base by taking advantage of the growing perception among the numerically weaker OBC groups that parties like the SP or the RJD were led by, and served only, the dominant Yadavs, and that, among the smaller Dalit communities, only the Jatavs have benefitted from the BSP. The BJP consolidated its base among these castes by invoking a broader Hindu religious identity and nationalism instead of caste as rallying points. But it was careful to blend this with incentives. In July 2021, the Modi government announced 27 per cent reservation for OBC students in medical and dental courses under the all-India quota. The income limit for the creamy layer among the OBCs was also revised upwards from Rs 6 lakh to Rs 8 lakh. Even the National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC) got constitutional status under the Modi regime.

In 2021, the government also introduced the Constitution (127th) Amendment Bill to restore the power of the states to draw up their own OBC lists after the Supreme Court set aside the Maharashtra government's decision to grant quota to the Marathas. Maharashtra deputy chief minister and BJP leader Devendra Fadnavis has recently promised to reinstate the quota. Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat has also said that the organisation supports reservations "as provided in the Constitution", a rather conspicuous U-turn from his 2015 position when he called for a "social review" of the reservation policy. There is also speculation that the Modi government may offer sub-categorisation of the 27 per cent OBC reservation as reportedly suggested by the Justice G. Rohini Commission. The commission was appointed in 2017 to examine the extent of the inequitable distribution of reservation benefits among the OBCs included in the central list, work out the mechanism for sub-categorisation within such OBCs and also recommend correction of any error in the central list. It submitted its report to President Droupadi Murmu on July 31.

The objective of sub-categorisation is to ensure that reservation benefits are not restricted only to certain numerically strong castes under the OBC umbrella. A 2018 working paper prepared by the Rohini Commission found that certain OBC castes such as Yadav, Kurmi, Jat, Saini, Thevar, Ezhava and Vokkaliga had cornered 97 per cent of the reserved jobs while a massive 37 per cent of the total OBC castes had no representation at all in the reserved seats. According to reports, the commission has suggested 3-4 sub-categorisations within the OBC quota to accommodate all castes.

Sub-categorisation of OBC castes is not a new concept per se. Eleven states, including Andhra Pradesh,